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John Bunch

Pianist John Bunch was born in Tipton, Indiana in 1921. He credits Fats Waller and Teddy Wilson as early influences, and his first significant work in jazz came with the big bands of Woody Herman, Benny Goodman and Maynard Ferguson. John has also been part of numerous well known combos including those led by Urbie Green, Al Cohn and Zoot Sims. In the late 60s he became Tony Bennett's accompanist for six years. Today John can be heard at festivals across the country and he often lends his talents to the recordings of musicians such as Scott Hamilton.

John was interviewed in Los Angeles on September 3, 1995 by Michael Woods. Mary Kopcza also participated briefly in the interview.

MW: We are filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. And today we have with us keyboard artist John Bunch. Pleased to meet you.

JB: Yeah. Nice to meet you.

MW: I wanted to ask, when did you first start playing piano and what led you to that?

JB: Well I had a different sort of beginning from a lot of people in this business. I'm from a small town in Indiana, you know, a very small town, and all of a sudden along about when I was about eleven years old, a guy moved in to town. He was a barber, and he taught kids how to play the piano in ten easy lessons. Learn how to play the piano in ten easy lessons. And the kids loved this guy. George Johnson was his name, and he was just great with children. And I turned out to be one of his prized students, you know? I learned very quickly and from the time I was thirteen years old I was playing with adults around Indiana. I thought I was a big shot.

MW: What town was it?

JB: Tipton, Indiana. It's still a small town.

MW: And you attended the great Indiana University.

JB: I did, later on, after the war, after World War II, yeah.

MW: Tell us about that. Tell us about the program that was going on at that time.

JB: Well you know they had a great music school, they still have you know. But at that time they frowned on jazz. Jazz was sort of a dirty word in those days, in 1946 or '5, whenever it was. And not only that but I wasn't a very good, legitimate musician. I couldn't read music very well and didn't have any classical training, so I wasn't accepted in music school so I was very disappointed. But I went there anyhow because there was a very good jazz band there that we made, we played a lot of dances, in Med Flory's band. He's quite well known right here in Los Angeles. And anyhow, so I wanted to play with his band so I signed up to be a student in speech. I was going to be a radio announcer. I

figured that's as close as I can get to music. And meanwhile I took piano lessons while I was there on the side you know, to learn to play classical music and read music better.

MW: Did you feel that that helped your overall technique and you were able to blend the two concepts?

JB: Yeah to a certain degree, yeah, to a certain degree. Although, well it's debatable about that, whether classical music helps your jazz or not. You know Benny Goodman played awful good before he ever took a lot of, studied a lot of classical music, so I'm not so sure that it really helps that much.

MW: You talked about World War II. There is word that you were a prisoner of war.

JB: Yeah.

MW: Tell us about that.

JB: Well I always was fascinated by airplanes when I was a little kid growing up, and my father had been in World War I and he was in the infantry. And he suffered terrible. I mean he never was wounded but he had terrible experiences in World War I in the mud. As he says he slept in the mud, and I thought, oh, I don't want to do that. If I have to go — in those days you had to, you know, young men had to go in the service, you had no choice. So I thought well, I love airplanes so I'll volunteer to be in the Air Force. So I was able to work my way up to become a flying officer you know in the Air Force, and flew missions over Germany as it turned out. And on the seventeenth mission I got shot down over Germany, deep into Germany, near Leipzig, and was taken prisoner.

MW: How did you get out of it?

JB: Well you know it was a scary, very frightening situation, the whole thing. All the missions were too you know. It was terrible. I was lucky to live through it. You know my pilot and my navigator were killed that day, the day I got shot down. You know the plane blew up and — a terrible thing. And then I went into a prison camp with other people who had had the same experiences or worse even some. So we were all in it together. We were young. I was 21 or 22, and somehow we— and we didn't get much to eat and we had a lot of misery in that prison camp, but we somehow pulled through. And I was one of the lucky ones. Some people died there, some people were killed trying to escape, so it was a pretty bad situation but anyhow we, through the grace of God, I made it.

MW: Do you feel that that has put a depth in your playing? An emotion? Because there is word that your ballad playing is just beautiful.

JB: Well thanks that's a nice compliment. I don't know. I think that that, coupled with the depression, you know I'm a child of — when I started taking piano lessons the depression hit this country. "Depression" was a wonderful word for it. That was a very depressed time. You can't put it in words. Everybody was broke. And my parents broke up, I was left with my mother, my mother had to raise me, she had to take a job in a restaurant, so

we were very poor. I think that had a little to do with the, if I have any feeling for music it probably helped a little to — sometimes I can use the music to remember those days. I'm not saying it's a necessity, you know, but it probably helps a little.

MW: Is there a specific art to playing a ballad? What goes into playing a great ballad on the keyboard?

JB: I don't know. Well I think you have to listen to records a lot. You know I was influenced by people like Johnny Hodges. I immediately think when you mention that I think of Johnny Hodges of Duke Ellington's band you know. And people like that. Yank Lawson, the trumpet player who just passed away a year ago. Certain musicians that I really think were — really had — almost made you cry when they play a ballad you know. Oh, the violinist, Ray Nance with Duke Ellington. I was crazy about Duke Ellington as you can tell. Certain people I think just — I think that inspiration helped me a lot. And you have to see them in person, too, which I have seen them a lot.

MW: Seeing a great artist in person is different from just getting the record, isn't it?

JB: Yeah. Particularly Johnny Hodges. He was a miracle man as far as I am concerned.

MW: Tell us about some of your influences, some of your keyboard influences.

JB: Well at the beginning you know since it happened when I was eleven, twelve years old taking those piano lessons, the music that appealed to me most then was the pianists Fats Waller and Teddy Wilson. Really different kinds of pianists but I loved them both. They were both great. Particularly Teddy. I even tried to imitate him, like get his records and try to play like him you know. And many years passed and I was able to meet him and we even traveled together on two different trips — one over in Russia for six weeks, and then later with Buddy Rich, I was with Buddy and he had his own trio and I got to know him which was a big thrill for me. So anyhow those were my first influences. Then later, after World War II I got in with the beboppers.

MW: Who was your favorite bebop artist on keyboard?

JB: Bud Powell. By far, yeah. He was outstanding. To me there was nobody like Bud Powell. He was so exciting. Yeah.

MW: You know you said that for a time you tried to play like Teddy Wilson. And another great artist, Clark Terry, talked about first imitation, then integration, then innovation.

JB: Well yeah, that's probably right. I never thought of it that way. That's right. That's right. Well you don't — I don't think a young person should push themselves to become unique, you just let it happen. Maybe it will never happen I don't know. But you know I'm thinking of Scott Hamilton. You know when Scott Hamilton first started I started playing with him when he was real young he came to New York. He was influenced very strongly by Ben Webster and I guess Lester Young. And but now, the years have passed and he's just sort of gradually evolved into his own style, you know it just happened.

People tell me they can identify me now when they hear a record. Well I feel that's a compliment. That's kind of nice.

MW: I want to ask you about being the accompanist and the music director for one of the greatest and most recognizable jazz voices there's ever been, Tony Bennett.

JB: Yeah. Well he was, you know I had a, I didn't have that kind of background at all. He, I guess he heard me play a solo when I used to be the relief piano player at the Hickory House in New York, and I had very little experience playing with singers and none as a conductor. And anyhow then later years passed and I was with Buddy Rich's band and it was a very exciting band he had, and Tony came, it happened right here in L.A. There was a club here that didn't last very long and we were playing and Tony Bennett was in the audience and he came up to sing. And I guess he must have liked what I played because he just faked the tune, we had no arrangement or anything, he just said do you know whatever it was "It's a Good Life" or some tune like that. And I guess he liked what he heard because like a couple, few weeks later I got a phone call that said, "Would you like to play with Tony Bennett?" I said oh my God, how am I going to do this? But anyhow I went over to his apartment and we did, I played a few tunes behind him. He says, "You got the job if you want it." I said, "Well, Tony, you know first of all I'm not a great sight reader. And I never conducted in my life." I practically tried to talk myself out of the job. That's why he was so nice. He said, "Well you can learn on the job." So that's what, the first, well quickly I took some conducting lessons from a guy that I know had played under conductors for years. And he gave me all of his music and all of his recent records and I took them all home and studied them and looked at the music and listened to the records. So in a few weeks I was able to learn how to do it you know. I guess I was a natural, that's what people say. It was very satisfying to prove, you know I held the job for six years, and very satisfying, but it's not, it's just not me. It gave me great satisfaction to be able to do that job but it was time for me to leave after six years and get back to doing what I like to do which is just play music.

MW: What's your favorite setting? Your overall favorite setting as a keyboard artist?

JB: My favorite setting would be just playing the piano in about a quartet with a good horn player. Maybe one or maybe two. With Sonny Rollins or somebody like that. Well not Sonny — the Sonny Rollins that I used to know. I hope he doesn't hear that. Are you going to interview him?

MW: We'll edit it out.

MK: We won't edit it but we won't show it to him.

MW: Talk to us briefly about your time with the Buddy Rich band, and about Buddy as a musician, as a leader, as an artist.

JB: Well Buddy Rich — I have worked and recorded long periods of time with three people. Tony Bennett, Buddy Rich and who else, let's see Tony Bennett, Buddy Rich and I can't think of who the third one was. Must be in good shape.

MW: Goodman?

JB: Goodman. How could I forget Benny Goodman? And somebody said you know you worked with these three people that have these ungodly reputations for being difficult to work for. And somebody told me, says, you're either a priest, a psychiatrist or you're just as nuts as they are. But anyhow you know they were all very difficult personalities to satisfy. But they're all great musicians. I'm not talking about the musicianship, they were all brilliant, you know and it was a big thrill I mean in each case to work with any of them.

MK: What were they like?

JB: Benny Goodman was, you just can't explain him. You never could understand what he wanted sometimes. And then he could turn and be an absolute dream guy, just the life of the party. He could turn out to be, tell jokes and if you told him a joke and he was in the right mood he'd collapse on the floor practically laughing. You know he could be just a really wonderful guy. But then he could turn around at a rehearsal and just practically insult a person, you know insult a musician. You know he'd give you a look like, a terrible look, he'd look you in the eye and go — as if he hated you. I got sort of used to it after a few years. And Buddy Rich was always very nice to me and always let me take solos and feature me and all that stuff. But he was really tough on the young musicians. I thought unreasonably so. He'd have tirades. He'd have great temper tantrums, almost like a little, child, a spoiled child. And it was sort of embarrassing to be there and witness that. I mean but he'd turn around the play the drums so great, I mean so exciting. You could hardly play with him you know. And when he'd feature me he would play so soft, as if it was my band. Always. When he'd feature that one tune he'd feature me on, it was so delicate. And he'd turn right around. This guy that had this temper, you know it's hard to figure out. And in Tony Bennett's case, I think in that case it was more familiarity. I just was so close to him all the time. A pianist that plays for a singer like that, every, it's so professional, I can't tell you, it's got to be exactly. It can't be just sort of exact. The tempos have to be on the button. And the bass player, if he — he can't be faking. It's got to be every note it's got to be exactly what the music says. It's a different kind of music from jazz you know. Maybe it's different now. He does have a, he works with a trio now. But see when I was with him it was a big orchestra, a great big orchestra. Even symphonies sometimes. And anyhow he wanted it just so. And the slow tempos were so slow. That takes a great concentration for a musician to play slow. It's not just concentrating to play fast. Slow is also very difficult.

MW: Sometimes it's harder than playing fast, isn't it?

JB: Yes almost. Because you have to, you can't dare take a drink before the show. At least I had to quit all that, no more, not even a martini before dinner or anything like that, just nothing. Because it took too much concentration. And then after a few years of that I finally got to where I decided it was time to leave. So anyhow, that's the sort of story that I had about those three.

MW: That's marvelous insights. You toured Europe I think in 1974.

JB: Well I've been to Europe a lot of times, you know, almost every year I go there with somebody it seems like, yeah.

MW: How is that different from playing in the United States?

JB: You mean playing in Europe compared to this country? Well you know, what you've got to realize that you know Europe, people don't hear jazz to the degree that they do in this country. They don't have the exposure that we do in America. I mean there's a lot of jazz played over there but not like here. So naturally they appreciate it more. Yeah. I think that's one of the reasons they do. Everybody says well people, a lot of musicians over the years, oh Europe, yeah, yeah. And some of them go over there and live over there. But sometimes when they live over there then it's a little different story, then they're local. And they're not heroes quite to the extent they were before.

MW: It's called maintaining a mystique?

JB: Yeah.

MW: Speaking of some of the exciting things that you've done, what did it feel like when you conducted the Los Angeles Philharmonic?

JB: Oh you know about that? Well that was just a wonderful experience. The not having, you know I told you I started out playing jazz, and I've always had this sort of feeling of inferiority, and I still do, it's in my system I can't, I feel like I don't deserve whatever success I've had. Well I mean to be up in front of an orchestra like that, it's tough. But I found out that the, you know I was always worried that maybe I might be challenged, my conducting might be challenged by great musicians like the caliber of the Los Angeles Philharmonic, I mean, what am I doing standing up in front of them you know? And it turns out that those musicians are so great, they're just great or they wouldn't even be there in the first place you know. And that music is so easy for them. They can look around you know and play it beautifully, perfect. And so they made me look like a great conductor. So it really turned out to be that it wasn't anything to be afraid of. And you know I also was given confidence by getting acquainted with some of the concert masters. Not the one here but in London I remember in London I got acquainted with the concert master of the London Philharmonic. He says oh you're — see I had known musicians well enough to know that if you don't really have to conduct, leave it alone,

don't conduct. They like that. Musicians like that. And they liked that about me that I only conducted when it was necessary. Once it goes into a steady tempo, one, two, three, four, I just sit down at the piano and play the piano. You know the only conducting that was necessary was when the tempo sort of changed, at the ending, usually at the ending or at the beginning. And they liked that they didn't want to see me waving my arms unnecessarily. So anyhow, I felt real good about that to get some kind of compliment from great musicians like that.

MW: But there's a rapport that takes place between a conductor and orchestra. And if they strike that rapport, great music happens.

JB: Beg your pardon?

MW: There's a rapport that takes place between a conductor and an orchestra.

JB: Yeah. I think my work, I've enjoyed playing background and being in bands. I've played in big bands more than most jazz piano players. I worked with Woody Herman, you know, Maynard Ferguson, and Benny Goodman's big bands. And I think being one of the boys in the band helped me understand musicians better. Because I know how I felt as a sideman so I mean these people in the orchestra, they're sort of sidemen. I hate to use that expression but you know and I know you can be, psychologically I learned how to conduct a rehearsal. Don't come on like a big, you know, just say what's necessary to get the music accomplished at the rehearsal you know. Also I would— sometimes Tony Bennett, he got confidence in me as the years went by, to where he wouldn't even show up at the rehearsal you know. And I'd play his part on the piano, the vocal part on the piano, so that the orchestra would know what the melody was, and I'd swing it a little and put a few little extra jazz notes in there, and I'd let them, I'd just show off to let them know I was one of them, I was one of the boys in the band, that I wasn't just some corny guy. And they liked it, I could tell they liked it, particularly with Duke Ellington's band and Basie and Woody Herman's band. I had to conduct all those bands, you know, behind Tony Bennett.

MK: You conducted Basie?

JB: Yeah. I even took his place at his birthday party one time. That was another thrill for me.

MW: Oh, tell us about that.

JB: Yeah. At the Waldorf Astoria, at the Grand Ballroom, they had a big birthday party, I think it was his 65th or 70th, I don't know 65th I guess. And I had been, we had just made a little tour. I mean I was still playing with Tony Bennett was my regular job. And we had just finished a tour of England with Count Basie's band backing up Tony Bennett and also doing their own music. And the guys kind of liked me. I used to travel on the bus. I preferred traveling on the bus with them, to riding in a limo with Tony. Not that I was trying to be down home, I just, to tell you the truth, for personal, I wanted to stay

away from Tony Bennett. I got so much of Tony Bennett and hearing him complain to the agent about the business and this and that, and so I liked going with the guys in the band. So anyhow, as a result of the band having confidence in me, they hired me to play at his birthday party with Basie's band up on the stage. So that was a great kick for me. And I grew up, you know, listening to Basie. They even used to call me "Count Bunch" when I was about fourteen, fifteen years old, because I could imitate him too you know. So I mean you know all these years passed and then here I am sitting playing old Basie's music. It was a big thrill.

MK: In front of him?

JB: Yeah, in front of Basie. And Basie was there and Jo Jones and all the many of his ex-musicians. Buck Clayton was in the audience and oh, it was an unbelievable experience. I just ran into a couple of the guys who remembered that. A couple of the Basie guys who are still with him — Mel — I can't remember the trombone player's name, been with them all these twenty something years. We were talking about that experience.

MW: Are there any other musicians that you played with that you shared a particularly fun or fulfilling experience with?

JB: Well there's a new guy that I have worked with that I find is just a delightful guy to play with and he's only 27 years old and he's also my tennis — he's the guy that ruined my wrist. We played tennis together. He lives right across the river. I live right in Manhattan and he lives right across the river and I get in my car and drive over and play tennis with him whenever I can. And his name is Harry Allen. You ever heard of him by any chance?

MW: No I haven't.

JB: Well he started out, now I met him when he was sixteen. Scott Hamilton used to let him sit in because he liked his playing and he loved Scott Hamilton. But now he's developed into, he's going to really be a — you're going to hear a lot about this guy Harry Allen. He doesn't play, he's a swing tenor man. Plus he's a delightful guy, you know, really a joy to play with, just a lot of fun, a lot of laughs, jokes all the time. So that's nice.

MW: Humor is a big part of this music, isn't it?

JB: Yeah. That's what my wife tells me. She says the funniest that I am is when I'm around musicians that I guess, when they get together somehow it just comes out, the humor somehow. I don't understand why, what it is. But if you're around it, well you seem to know a lot about that. I observed it myself. It's just jokes and so forth, a lot of jokes.

MW: The way that you've learned, you've played with a lot of great musicians, is jazz education different now? And is it better or is it missing something?

JB: Well see you're asking the wrong guy. I don't know anything about jazz education. I don't even understand how there could be such a term as jazz education. But I know it's going on. In fact the very university, Indiana University where I went to school, and I

said they frowned on jazz. Well now it's known as one of the best schools I guess in the country to teach jazz. And so I mean never having, no one's ever asked me to you know, lecture or say anything in front of young students, so I just wouldn't know much about that. I guess there are ways of teaching it but I don't know how it's done really. Ignorant about that. You know one pianist, by the way, when he was about eighteen years old, kept hanging around me trying to get me to teach, you know give him lessons. And I told him I wouldn't know how to teach and you have to want to do that. You have to have desire for that. And he finally talked me into coming, I said, alright, come up to my apartment and I want to hear you play. This guy came up there and played so much more piano than I do — it was embarrassing. His name was Mike LeDonne. Have you ever heard of him? Boy he's really great. He's becoming a hell of a piano player. He's playing with people like Milt Jackson quite a lot. He's playing with Sonny Rollins lately too. So I mean I told him, you're already playing with guys that I wanted to play with all my life and never got a chance to you know, really. So it was — I just felt like there was nothing I could show him you know. Maybe I'm putting myself down when I say that. Maybe there is something. I don't know what it would be though. I think that a young person, if they have a lot of talent, records are very important. Scott Hamilton's got a record collection you wouldn't believe. He knows much more about saxophone players than I do. He's put together some tapes for me that are wonderful stuff that I never even knew existed, you know like — so I'm saying that he learned a lot from listening to records. He lived in, up there in a small town outside of Providence, Rhode Island you know and like I lived in this very small farm town. But the records, you know I started hearing these records. And if you've got really the talent, you know you can steal from these guys. Steal whatever you can. It's fun when you're a kid it's really fun to try to play like them you know. And I think that's how you learn.

MW: If you could write your own ticket for the next three or four years — play with anybody, go anywhere, do anything, your dream requisition — what would be on it?

JB: Well like I told Mike LeDonne, I'd like to play with Milt Jackson. There's so few guys around, well you know like I said I liked Sonny Rollins the way he used to play back 30 years ago. And I still like him, he's a wonderful guy, it's just that he's so far out. But I mean anyhow, I would like to play with, you know like I say I'm old enough that I started with the old even Dixieland you know I played with a lot of Dixieland bands too. And I don't put any of that down. But I just happened to, my favorite is sort of bebop kind of music, you know and I'd love to be able to play with somebody like Milt Jackson because he's one of the few outstanding guys I can think of that can lead a quartet. So that would be my ultimate I guess. Yeah.

MW: Well thank you very much for conversing with us. Mary do you have another question you might ask?

MK: I'm just off on this sideline. John you were talking about some of the people that had great stories that we talked to. And you mentioned Milt Hinton and Doc Cheatham. I take it that you know some of those stories? Do you? Would you share any of them?

JB: Well I can't think of many stories in relation to those two. I'm not a very good, I don't have a very good memory. As far as, I was just telling some people today you know I also worked with Gene Krupa quite a lot in the quartet. With Charlie Ventura. He was one of the great guys, one of the nicest guys, personally. The complete opposite from these three guys that I worked long periods of time on. And I should put in a word, speaking of nice guys that had fame and everything, Woody Herman was another one that I worked for, and they were both great. Now Gene, Gene was here's an example of how nice he was. When I got that job we couldn't find any, there was nothing written down for that quartet, it had to be memorized. So we had to have a rehearsal for my benefit. And we couldn't find, things were very busy in New York then and you couldn't find a rehearsal hall just at the drop of a hat like that, and I said, well if you don't mind, come up to my place, I have a Steinway grand and I have a set of drums, I had a bass even. Because I used to like to have jam sessions at my apartment. And he asked me about the drums, and I said they are Slingerland drums, which that was his company, and he said okay, I'll bring the cymbals and we'll rehearse up at your place. So we came up there and when he was up there he says what kind of cymbals do you have? And I showed him mine and he didn't say anything. And a year or two passed and I started working with him and a year or two passed. And one time we were in Boston and we met Zildjian who is the great cymbal maker. Just out of the clear blue he says, "hey, why don't you give John Bunch some cymbals? Send John Bunch some cymbals. He's got a nice set of drums but he doesn't have very good cymbals." He remembered that. So I didn't think anything, I thought oh, nothing will ever happen. And about two or three weeks later I get a big special package, very heavy, full of these cymbals. The best cymbals, hand picked by Zildjian himself, thanks to Gene. I mean it was just the kind of a guy he was, you know. So, you know, oh and when I unwrapped them they were sort of dirty looking and I'm thinking, not knowing anything about drums, I thought oh, you didn't give me nice new cymbals. And I showed them to, I think it was Jake Hanna or somebody, and he said, "My, those are wonderful cymbals," he says, "hand picked, they're perfect." They were worth, I don't know, a lot of money. He says, "You can't find cymbals like that." So anyhow, thanks to Gene I got all these wonderful things and the memory, I mean, that he could remember that you know. To take time to remember something.

MW: Well thank you very much.

JB: Okay.

MW: And we've enjoyed talking with you. This has been an interview with John Bunch for the Hamilton Jazz Archive. Thank you.

JB: You are a wonderful interviewer really, delightful, delightful. Because I'm not much of a talker but you really —

MW: I think you underestimate yourself.

JB: Well, yeah, but you know how to do it.